

DOCUMENTATION · VI.0.1

SYNODE

Σύνοδος

*Design system, CSS architecture and elegance review for the synode.space
parallax photography landing page.*

Style guide: Hellenic Manuscript & Classical Serif

Files: index.html · css/site.css · css/layout.css · js/parallax.js

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I · OVERVIEW

Synode is a single-scroll fashion photography journal for *synode.space*. There is no main menu: the page reads top to bottom like a manuscript, in seven movements. Depth comes from slow parallax on photographs, sticky captions that hold while plates drift past, and stacked leaves that settle over one another. Everything else is restraint: parchment ground, ink type, hairline gold rules and one rust accent.

PAGE SEQUENCE

#	SECTION	TECHNIQUE	CLASS
I	Hero — title inscription over a full-bleed plate	Two-layer parallax: plate 0.35 down, inscription 0.12 up	.hero
II	Prologue — wide-margin text with drop cap	Asymmetric folio grid, reveal on enter	.folio
III	Chapter I · Aegean	Sticky caption column + plates drifting at ± 0.05 –0.08	.chapter
IV	Interlude — inscription band	Full-bleed parallax background, 0.2	.interlude
V	Chapter II · Terracotta	CSS sticky stacked leaves, offset like folio pages	.stack
VI	Chapter III · Laurel	Asymmetric 12-column contact sheet	.gallery
VII	Colophon — contact, return to top	Static dark ground	.colophon

FILE STRUCTURE

index.html	single page, semantic sections, no <nav>
css/site.css	tokens, base, typography, ornament, components, reveal
css/layout.css	hero, folio, chapter, interlude, stack, gallery, colophon, responsive
js/parallax.js	~70 lines, no dependencies: parallax offsets + reveal
docs/src/	this document's source (HTML) and build script
docs/synode-v1.0.1.pdf	this document

Load order is `site.css` then `layout.css`: layout consumes the tokens declared in site.

2 · CSS styling summary

COLOUR TOKENS

TOKEN	HEX	ROLE	SHARE
 <code>--parchment-marble</code>	#F7F4EE	Page canvas	60%
 <code>--aegean-ink</code>	#0C1821	Type; hero, interlude, colophon grounds	30%
 <code>--amphora-rust</code>	#A34828	Drop caps, eyebrows, plate numbers, button, focus	10%
 <code>--hellenic-gold</code>	#C29B38	1px rules at 0.4 opacity; text only on ink	
 <code>--laurel-leaf</code>	#516053	Captions, meta, secondary notes	—
 <code>--thera-white</code>	#FFFFFF	Stacked leaf cards, button text	—

Semantic aliases (`--color-bg`, `--color-text`, `--color-muted`, `--color-accent`, `--color-ornament`, `--color-surface`) sit above the palette so a future dark or seasonal theme only remaps six lines.

TYPE SCALE (FLUID, 360 → 1440PX)

LEVEL	CLASS	FAMILY / WEIGHT	SIZE	TRACKING
Display H1	<code>.display</code>	Cinzel 900, uppercase	48 → 72px	+0.15em
Section H2	<code>.section-title</code>	Bodoni Moda 600 (optical size auto)	32 → 40px	+0.05em
Subsection H3	<code>.subhead</code>	Cinzel 400, uppercase	20 → 24px	+0.20em
Body	<code>body</code>	EB Garamond 400, old-style figures	16 → 18px / 1.65	0
Caption / meta	<code>.caption</code> <code>.meta</code>	Spectral italic 400	13 → 14px	+0.02em
Eyebrow	<code>.eyebrow</code>	Cinzel 400, uppercase, rust	12px	+0.30em
Drop cap	<code>.dropcap</code>	Cinzel Decorative 700, rust; <code>initial-letter: 3</code> where supported	3 lines	—
Greek	<code>.hero__greek</code>	GFS Didot (Greek only), gold on ink	20 → 28px	+0.08em

The reading column is capped at 62ch. Display type receives a negative right margin equal to its tracking so centred capitals are optically, not mathematically, centred.

LAYOUT

- **Folio grid** — three columns: gloss margin (min 9rem), reading column (max 40rem), and a deliberately empty outer margin 1.6× wider. Padding is 5% left, 10% right on desktop, collapsing to max(16px, 6%)

below 960px.

- **Sticky chapter** — caption column is `position: sticky; top: 18vh`; plates sit on a 6-column sub-grid with alternating offsets (1–5, 3–7, 1–7).
- **Stacked leaves** — each leaf is a 100svh sticky container; leaves 2 and 3 rest 1.25rem lower so the previous edge stays visible. On phones (<720px) stacking is switched off and leaves simply follow each other.
- **Contact sheet** — 12 columns with negative and positive margin offsets for an asymmetric, hand-laid feel; two columns on phones.

MOTION

- Parallax writes a single custom property, `--py`, consumed by `transform: translate3d()`. Only transforms animate, so scrolling stays on the compositor.
- An IntersectionObserver keeps only on-screen layers in the update set; updates are batched in `requestAnimationFrame`. Native scrolling is never intercepted.
- Speeds are deliberately small: 0.02–0.12 for plates, 0.2–0.35 for backgrounds. Background layers are oversized (`inset: -12% / -25%`) so no edge can show.
- Text blocks fade up 1.5rem over 900ms on `cubic-bezier(.22, .61, .36, 1)`, once.
- `prefers-reduced-motion` disables parallax, reveal, the scroll cue and image zoom, and turns off smooth scrolling.

3 · Elegance review

Review of the pasted Hellenic Manuscript guide as a system for a fashion photography site, with what v1.0.1 already does about each point.

Palette restraint & temperature	9 / 10
Type pairing (display / section / body)	8 / 10
Accessibility of the palette as specified	6 / 10
Spacing & manuscript proportion	9 / 10
Economy (number of typefaces)	6 / 10
Overall, as written	8 / 10

WHAT IS ALREADY ELEGANT

- **Warm, not white.** Ink on parchment gives 16.4:1 contrast without the glare of #000 on #FFF. Photography reads richer on a warm ground, and the parchment tint lets plates float.
- **The 60/30/10 split maps naturally onto a scroll page:** parchment for reading, ink for the three cinematic bands (hero, interlude, colophon), rust and gold only as points of light.
- **Lapidary capitals + Didone + Garamond** is a historically coherent trio: Roman inscription for titles, eighteenth-century high contrast for sections, Renaissance text face for reading.

- **Hairline gold at 40% opacity** is the right strength: it reads as ruling on a page, not as decoration.
- **Asymmetric margins** give the photographs room and stop the page from looking like a template.

CONTRAST AUDIT (WCAG 2.2)

FOREGROUND	ON PARCHMENT	ON AEGEAN INK
Aegean Ink	16.37 AAA	—
Amphora Rust	5.44 AA	3.01 large text only
Hellenic Gold	2.38 fails	6.88 AA
Laurel Leaf	6.08 AA	2.69 fails
White on Rust (button)	5.97 AA	

The one real problem in the guide: it assigns Hellenic Gold to “metadata”. On parchment, gold text is 2.38:1 and unreadable for many people. v1.0.1 resolves this by setting meta in Laurel on light grounds and allowing gold text only on Aegean Ink (`.meta--gold`, hero, colophon). Gold on parchment is used for rules only.

REFINEMENTS RECOMMENDED FOR V1.1

1. **Fewer voices.** The guide calls on six families (Cinzel, Cinzel Decorative, Bodoni Moda, GFS Didot, EB Garamond, Spectral). EB Garamond's own italic is one of the finest and could replace Spectral; Cinzel Decorative can be subset to the few drop-cap letters with Google Fonts' `&text=` parameter. That cuts roughly a third of the font payload and tightens the page's voice.
2. **“Thick, high-contrast” headers.** Cinzel is an inscriptional face with low stroke contrast; the high contrast lives in Bodoni Moda. The guide's wording conflates the two. Consider Cinzel 700 instead of 900 for the hero: at 72px with +0.15em tracking, 900 starts to look heavy beside fine photography.
3. **Didone tracking.** +0.05em suits all-caps, but loosens lowercase Bodoni. For title-case H2s, +0.01–0.02em keeps the hairlines crisp. (This document already uses +0.02em for its H2s for comparison.)
4. **Thera White vs parchment.** Pure #FFF next to #F7F4EE can read slightly cool. Keep it for the stacked leaves, where the lift is intentional, but don't spread it to other surfaces.
5. **GFS Didot** should stay for Greek text only (as in the hero's Σύντομος). For Latin H2s, Bodoni Moda has the better Latin glyphs and optical sizes.
6. **Rust on ink** (3.01:1) works for the colophon button, where white text sits on a rust fill, but never set rust text directly on ink below 24px.

4 • Production notes

REPLACING THE PLACEHOLDER PHOTOGRAPHY

The demo uses `picsum.photos` seeded placeholders. Replace each `src` with your own plates, ideally as AVIF/WebP with `srcset`. Keep the hero at $\geq 2000\text{px}$ wide and preload it. A light tonal filter (`saturate(.82) sepia(.12)`) pulls mixed sources toward the palette; remove it in `layout.css §1` if your grading is already final.

ADDING A PARALLAX LAYER

```
<figure class="plate" data-speed="0.06">  positive = slower than scroll, negative =  
faster  
  <div class="plate__frame"><img ...></div>  
  <figcaption class="caption"><span class="caption__no">11</span> ...</figcaption>  
</figure>
```

Background layers need headroom: $\text{inset} \geq \text{speed} \times (\text{viewport} + \text{section height}) / 2$.

BROWSER SUPPORT

Evergreen Chromium, Firefox and Safari. `color-mix()`, `svh`, `text-wrap: balance` and `initial-letter` degrade gracefully: fallbacks are provided for viewport units and the drop cap, and balance is cosmetic.

REBUILDING THIS PDF

```
sh docs/src/build-pdf.sh
```

CHANGELOG

1.0.1 — Gold restricted to dark grounds; interlude quote measure fixed; parallax measures each layer's own position; stacked leaves disabled on phones.

1.0.0 — Initial single-scroll layout, tokens and parallax engine.